Digital

WEBB FAMILY REUNION
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HENRY AND DELLA WEBB

By
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We live in a special time and in a very special place. There are those who say we are a chosen people living in a choice land – the land of America.

Each one of us has a story to tell. The things we do are important to us, and when the last history book will close, our story will be important to those who follow after us.

Tonight, our story is a small part of the lives of Henry and Della Webb. They were and are great people in the lives of all who have gathered here tonight. To know them better helps each of us to understand who we are, where we came from and why we are here. We know of their honesty, their hard work, how they loved their family and of their love and trust in their God.

Come with us to Linden, Missouri to begin our story. This is where Henry's father, Edward Milo, was born to Edward Milo Webb Sr. and Caroline Amelia Owens on March 8, 1847. They called him Eddie for short, as he began his life in that humble home on the flat lands of Missouri. The family was very poor, but this did not deter them from listening to the message of Joseph Smith concerning a new book- a book that would lead us to eternal life and exaltation. The book was called the Book of Mormon. The Webb family accepted its teachings and were baptized members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter Day Saints.

With Brigham Young as the new president and prophet of the church, it became evident that the members must seek a new home where they could worship. There was great persecution of the saints at that time, and the prophet told them to move west to the Rocky Mountains.

The Webb family made the decision to join the others and cross the plains in search of religious freedom. They prepared themselves the best they could, took their meager belongings and joined the others in the migration west. The trip was difficult, and it tried the very souls of those who put religious freedom before their comforts.

Eddie was only five years old when the family began the trek across the plains. At that age, he was too small to help his parents. Somewhere on the trail, his father died and it became a very trying time for his young mother to carry on.

It was known that he served in the Blackhawk War as a soldier, but there is no other record of his youth.

During this time, many members of the Mormon Church were asked by leaders of the church to live plural marriage. Although the church and leaders approved it, not all practiced the principle.

On June 6, 1870 Edward Milo was married to his first wife, Ellen Ashman. They had fourteen children from 1870-1898. On April 10, 1873, Edward Milo was married to his second wife, Sarah Elizabeth Carling, the mother of Jonathan Henry. This union brought twelve children.

In 1876, the Webb family moved to Orderville, Utah to live the United Order, as directed by the church leaders at that time. Two years later, Edward would marry his third wife, Charlotte Martha Maxwell, Aunt Lottie, on September 13, 1878. She would give birth to five children.

After nine years in Orderville, the church authorities disbanded the small Utah town in 1885. They asked the families to move to other settlements. The next year, the Webb family gathered their belongings and made preparations for the move to Mexico, where they would settle the country and establish the church. They traveled the dusty and muddy road to the South. They traveled the Honeymoon Trail, across the deep canyons, through the pine tangled plateaus and barren deserts to the mighty Colorado River.

John D. Lee operated a ferry across the Colorado River for the travelers. He called his home the Lonely Dell. He had many personal problems but also a great desire to serve his fellow men. This was his way to show his love to those who were called to be pioneers.

The Webb family crossed the Colorado River and made their way to the valley along the Little Colorado Basin in northeast Arizona. They arrived in the small town of Woodruff, Arizona on May 2, 1886. They planned a short rest but their visit lasted a lot longer. One month later, Edward Milo's wife Sarah, gave birth to a new

son. His name would be Jonathan Henry. It was on June 21, 1886 that this son was born in the small town in the sandstone desert.

To the south of Woodruff was another town settled by Mormon pioneers. They had established a church school in the town of Snowflake which would be called "The Academy". Students would come from all over to get more education. They had no teachers or a principal to run the school. Edward and his wife Charlotte were hired to teach and run the school.

Edward Milo had very little formal schooling. One summer when he was 17 years old, he walked 140 miles into Salt Lake City to attend summer school. When the summer was over, he walked 140 miles home. Even with so little formal education, he spent virtually his entire adult life as an educator. He was a teacher, a principal, and even the founder of schools in Utah, Arizona and Mexico.

While in Woodruff, Edward Milo served as Bishop of that small ward. He wrote many songs and poems-some to his family. To Sarah Elizabeth he penned:

"Sweet is the thoughts of being loved
and loving in return."

Now, we turn to another family. Wilford Ray and his wife Elsie Margaret Mortensen had many of the same experiences as the Webb family and other families who were willing to follow the church leaders and move when asked.

The Ray family was sent to Mexico. They first settled in Arizona in Sunset, now known as Joseph City. They stayed for awhile and moved on to Sonora, Mexico. It was in Sonora on June 13, 1891 that Margaret gave birth to a baby girl. Her name was Della Ray. We came to know her as Grandma Webb.

On June 18, 1898, Edward Milo Webb moved his family to Mexico. It took two months to travel to Dublan. They moved to Colinia Garcia in 1904 and on to Colinia Morelos two years later.

Henry worked where he could. At one time, he was in El Paso, Texas working for a rich railroad man. Here, he learned about steam. He would have stayed, but his father told him to come home. He was afraid the man in El Paso with lots of money would not be a good influence for the young Henry. He returned to Mexico and when he was 17 years old, he worked in a sawmill. While at this sawmill, he became a part of the history of the Southwest.

In 1889, the Apache Kid was convicted of killing a man south of Globe in the Pinal Mountains. He escaped and fled. Many stories were told of him fleeing into Mexico. He became a feared outlaw and was know throughout the Southwest. In 1895 or 1896, near the Mormon settlement in western Chihuahua, the Apache Kid and a small band of followers attacked an outlying ranch and killed a Mrs. Thompson and her children. Pursuit by the armed ranchers and Mexican soldiers was unsuccessful, although the pursuers were close enough at times to see the Kid at a distance.

About a year later, at a ranch in Cave Valley, near the town of Pacheco, the Indian raiding party returned to steal corn in a field. There were shots exchanged and the Indians ran off. The next day, the ranchers caught up to them. Most of them scattered like quail, but the Apache Kid and his wife stood their ground. She had her papoose on her back during the fight. The Kid was killed and his wife seized the Kid's rifle and began to fire at the rancher. She was then killed by a bullet which also struck her papoose.

The bodies were buried, but the Mexican government later exhumed the bodies to positively identify the Apache Kid. The bodies were then reburied in very shallow graves by the Mexican authorities. Those shallow graves caused the young Henry Webb some exciting moments at the sawmill.

It was Henry's job to transport the sawdust from the mill to a flat area, some distance outside the mill. The sawdust was set afire and slowly it would burn. The wind would blow, causing pot holes all over the flat. One day, to his surprise, Henry saw a human skull looking up at him from one of the pits. He ran to report his findings and was told, "Don't be scared, son. What you just saw was the skull of either the Apache Kid or his wife. The bones of his child are out there somewhere." This story was printed in the Arizona Republic and told by Grandpa Webb to many of his family and friends.

It was in Colonia Morelos that Della Ray met Henry Webb. After the prescribed courtship, she agreed to marry him. August 16, 1908, Henry and Della were married by Bishop Charles Lilly White. On April 12, 1913, they traveled to Salt Lake City to be sealed in the temple.

They were living in Morelos, Sonora, Mexico when Thora, their first child was born. This was on September 4, 1909. Two years later on October 19, 1911, Della gave birth to their first son, Ray.

Jobs were scarce in Mexico, so Henry worked where he could. At one time, he worked at a flourmill which operated until 1951.

When the Mexican Revolution began to pour into the border towns, the Mormon settlements were affected by the fighting. Several members were killed,and finally the L.D.S. church authorities and the United States government ordered the settlers to leave Mexico immediately and to cross the border for their own protection. They returned to the U.S. on Aug 12, 1912. They found themselves refugees in their homeland. Many of the settlers had no place to go for help. Some had families in Utah and others had family in the East. The U.S. government provided large tents to help the misplaced families. They did what they could, but in many cases, it was not enough.

The Henry Webb family moved first to Douglas, then on to Tucson. Henry worked for his half brother Harvey on a dairy ranch in Tucson. Harvey was the son of Aunt Ellen, Edward Milo's first wife. Henry also drove a milk truck for Uncle Frank, Harvey's brother.

The Ray family moved to a ranch 6 miles west of Tucson where they cleared brush from the land. From Tucson, the Webb family found their way to the Graham Mountains, where there were sawmills and tall timber. Thatcher was the birthplace of their third child, Karl. He was born on January 5, 1914.

Henry found work in the sawmill at Ash Creek, somewhere on the Graham Mountains. He was a great asset to the sawmill, as he had some knowledge of a steam mill. He knew how to work in primitive conditions where there were few supplies and tools.

Henry had a special talent. He had the ability to fix what was broken and to make something you didn't have from something you did. Grandma Webb learned to make a home wherever her house was. She made do with a government tent in the Graham Mountains.

Many of us have heard Grandpa tell stories of the giant flume constructed on the north side of Mt. Graham. This was a new experience for Henry as Mt. Graham was a tough and rugged mountain. The canyons were deep and challenging to the hard-working lumbermen in those desert mountains. Transportation was one

of the most difficult problems the lumbermen faced. Most of the time, the only solution was to use their trusted wagons and teams of horses.

There were several sawmills built and operated on the Graham Mountains. From what we know, Henry worked on the mill in Ash Creek. This was one of the larger mills and it was located in the middle of the timber. It was difficult to move the logs and lumber on the mountain, so they continued to struggle to find a means to get the lumber to the valley below. It was decided to build a long slide, or a flume, down the mountain that would carry both logs and lumber. The flume would be built with wood, since this was the only material they had and could afford. Work started in 1924 and was completed in 1925. The flume used for a short time and then abandoned in 1926. It was called a flume because water flowed in the trough to reduce friction and not allow the wood to catch on fire. It crossed the deep canyons and followed the mountain slopes with some of the trestles rising 70 feet into the air. There are many storied told of men riding logs and lumber down the flume. One story was about a dead man being strapped to a board and sent sailing down the mountain to the valley.

From Thatcher, they moved to Pinedale, where sawmills became the center of their lives in making a living. Pinedale was in the heart of tall pine trees, and due to transportation problems of logs and lumber, the mills were moved as close to the trees as possible. The sawmill crew began to take form as another son, Maurice, was born on September 13, 1916.

The church was fully organized in Pinedale, and since there was always need for good, willing men, Henry was put to work. He served as counselor to two bishops, A.J. Brewer and Elija Thomas Jr. He also served as Superintendent of the YMMIA in the Pinedale Ward.

In 1917, the family moved to Show Low, some 15 miles to the east. It was here where the Webb's sawmill family got into a business of their own. Frank Ellsworth had a small mill on his ranch 1 mile south of town. Henry bought the steam mill and put it to work. Henry's sawmill crew began to form as his fourth son, Junius, was born in Show Low on May 10, 1918.

To be a sawmiller, one of the first things to learn is the talk. It's important to know what is a: V-belt, flat belt, feed works, curf, cant hook, choker, tongs, line shaft, gut chain, wrapper, frozen logs, block setter, and dogger. They had to also learn a sign language different than any other sign language in use. Many of these

words are still used today, as this generation continues to work in the lumber business and in the logwoods.

The family moved back to Pinedale where Gwen was born in the fall, October 2, 1919. The winters were cold and the snow was very deep. It was difficult to log and to run a sawmill during those cold winters. February 22, 1923, yet another girl came into the family. Zola was born in Pinedale. One year later, while still in Pinedale, another part of the logging crew came into being as Jay was born October 5, 1924.

Since the cold weather continued to cause great difficulty to work during the winter, Henry decided there may be a better way to spend the winter. In November 1926, the family moved to the Valley so Henry could build houses and provide for the family. In west Mesa and far east Tempe, where Watson's now have a flower shop, there was a medical clinic where Louise was born on March 28, 1927. Thus, she is the only Webb child born in a birthing facility.

During 1929, the Webb family returned to the mountains to continue the sawmill business. They moved to Lakeside as their last move, and spent the rest of their lives in that mountain setting. April 28, 1930, the final crew member, June, came to the Webb family. He too soon learned what sawdust and hard work were all about.

In 1936, Henry built the family home by the lake that was to be their home until their passing. J.H. Webb and Sons became a well- known business name around the state. They built and operated mills in many locations in the mountains. There were mills on the Ellsworth Ranch and Pinedale, Vernon, on the ranch in Lakeside, Mt. Graham, Forest Dale, Canyon Day, Hill Top, and East Fork.

Since sawdust was in the Webb's bloodstream, Thora married into another sawmill family – the Petersens. Golden operated a mill south of Pinedale where the winters were long and cold. He too experienced cold and snowy winters trying to produce lumber for market.

Sawmills were their livelihood, but their family was the lifeblood of Henry and Della. With ten children all raised to adulthood, and grandkids all over the mountain, Henry and Della had a celebration. On August 16, 1957, they celebrated 50 years of marriage. All of their children were present. Thora was married to Golden Petersen. They had two girls. Ray married Ina Holliday and they had ten children. Karl married Coral Frost and they were the parents of five children. Reese

married Luella Ballard and they had six children. Junius married Verena Fish and they had two children. Gwen married Clarence Penrod and they had three children. Zola never married. Jay married Marion Brenay and they had four children. Louise married Cecil McDowell and they were the parents of four children. June married Sherry Cluff and they had eight children.

In addition to her own ten children, Grandma helped raise her sister, Marguerite, and brother, Waldo Ray. Max and Hattie Sadler were the children of Edna and Max Sadler of the Ray family. Edna passed away and until Max remarried, Grandma raised Max and Hattie as her own. Louise didn't know until she was grown that Waldo wasn't her brother. She called him Waldo Ray Webb.

Grandpa and Grandma set the standard for service in the church. She wrote in her life history, "I was active all my life in the service of the church." She served as YWMIA president and teacher; Relief Society president and class leader; visiting teacher (most of her life); Primary president and teacher; and as a Stake missionary with Grandpa. She also enjoyed working in the temple. Grandma lived by standards not set by man. Taken from her patriarchal blessing in part, she was given many promises. "Mother Sarah's blessings are yours- that your prosperity shall be great. A righteous branch shall spring from you. These shall be mighty men and women in the Second Coming of our Redeemer. The Lord delights in you, and will bless you and your posterity with the blessings of the heaven and earth."

The children of Henry and Della have responded in service as they knew they should. They are great people. Twenty-four have served as Stake Clerks, Stake High Councilors and in Stake Presidencies. Ninety-nine have served as Ward Clerks, Quorum leaders and in Bishoprics. One hundred thirty nine have filled missions. Many have served as Stake and Ward organization leaders, teachers and secretaries.

In closing, it would only be fitting that we honor those of our family who have passed away. Fred McNeil was the first to pass away. He died on April 4, 1947. He was the family jokester. He loved to see someone laugh. He passed away as a young man. He left Aunt Louise a widow at age 19 with two small children to care for-Kayle and Cheryl.

A.G. Petersen died in 1968 after a very long illnes. He was a man who liked to make things happen. He had a tender heart when it came to his two daughters and his wife Thora. His grandkids were the love of his life. He was a hard worker and considered one of the better sawmillers on the mountain.

Thora was the big sister to the Webb clan. She was a great cook and loved to sew for her girls and everyone else, but never herself. She sang beautifully and would dance whenever she could. As others, her grandkids made her life complete. Her great disappointment was only being able to hold her first great grandchild one time before she passed away in 1974.

Luella passed away on March 30, 1977. She was the "Bell of the Ball". Her life was full of service to others. Until the time of her passing, she always was willing to sew burial clothes for many throughout northern Arizona. She taught her children to be the very best, and it shows. After her passing, Uncle Reese married another jewel, Cheryl.

Junius was the quiet one. He never said a bad word about anyone. He was a hard worker who never complained of those difficult times in life. Completely dependable in every aspect of his life, he served 25 years as clerk in the church, before passing away July 15, 1985.

Clarence, or Penrod as he was affectionately called, was loved for his infectious laugh. When he was around, there was never a dull moment. He loved his family. Lance was his pride and joy. He loved to watch him compete in sports at all levels. He loved his grandchildren and they knew it. He passed away in 1986.

Zola was the California girl. She spent many years living on the Coast. Her home was always open and she loved to have everyone come to see her. She loved horses, and at one time, wanted to be a trick rider. She never married and only had one love, Charles Porterfield. Her beautiful hair was her trademark.

On a beautiful winter day, Feb. 20, 1999, the Webb family and friends gathered at the Lakeside Stake Center to honor the passing of their loved one – Henry Ray Webb. Ray was the peacemaker of the family and was loved by all who knew him. He passed away Feb. 18, 1999 in Mesa, Arizona, where he was being cared for in a nursing home. He was buried in Lakeside, among the tall pines which he loved so much. He was an LDS Bishop and served all of his life in the church. He loved his family and served them throughout his life.

Eight grandchildren, or the spouses of grandchildren, have also passed away, as well as two great-grandchildren.

We close with a tribute to Grandpa and Grandma Webb written by their great-granddaughter Dori Thompson.